



**FANS GREET
TENDULKAR
AT BANGALORE'S
CHINNASWAMY
STADIUM (LEFT);
MARKS HIS
ASSOCIATION
WITH ADIDAS**



world record and has scored over 1,000 runs in a calendar year in ODIs 7 times.

his rehab routine diligently and when he returned he was like a gleaming new automobile. "At last I am injury free," he said when I met him. He was back to fighting on one front, back to playing the kind of shots only he can.

Indeed, it is his strokeplay that makes him the bridge between two generations of Indian cricketers. One, that subjugated natural desires and played a conservative game in keeping with the times; and the other that bats like there is no tomorrow. In between something remarkable happened to India. As we emerged from the economic backwaters, we grew into a proud nation that learnt to stand up for itself, that cast aside the shadow of pessimism. Tendulkar was the hero that symbolised this transition. A

nation that had its roots in non-violence had produced an aggressor in keeping with the times. A generation found its style in Tendulkar and rejoiced in adding up the numbers he produced for it was like adding their own.

Inevitably the captaincy would come to him; not once but twice and even a third had he so willed. It remains a strange aberration in his career, crystal in a crown of diamonds. Unlike everything else in the game, even leg break bowling, captaincy never seemed to sit lightly on him. Maybe it

was about the lack of control, the inability to come to terms with the fact that he didn't hold all the cards. Maybe it was about having to understand people who didn't think like him; maybe it was about getting

into the minds of people who tried hard but had to live with insecurity. Maybe, just maybe, he understood cricket better than he did cricketers. If so, he wasn't the first and he certainly won't be the last. It is a fate that tends to befall those that nature gives in grand measure.

Yet, he has been the finest cricketer of his era. You cannot say more and comparisons across eras are at best academic and inevitably futile. It can be said of very few that they have achieved what was ordained of them!

And one day the time will come when he will bid goodbye to cricket. Will he then retire to a world of children, food and cars? Will he still, on his travels around the world, charm chefs into giving him their recipes for use in his fine restaurant? Will he have the space to drive his Ferrari? I don't know. I suspect, like his many fans around the world, I don't want to know. ■

Rs 180

**crore is the worth of
his 2006 sponsor-
ship deal. He has the
most sponsorships
in world cricket.**